



BEAUTIFYING TEMPLES
The Kashi Vishwanath Dham corridor in Varanasi, (below) the Mahakal Lok corridor in Ujjain, Madhya Pradesh

auspicious period for the *pran pratishtha*, the ceremony to bestow divinity on the newly sculpted Balak Ram idol, would be January 22.

In the run-up to the ceremony, Modi undertook a rigorous 11-day *yama-niyama-anushthan* fast, including sleeping on the ground, to perform his duties as the yajman. To dispel the notion that Ram was a calling only for those living in the North, the prime minister went on a temple run in both the West and the South, visiting famous shrines in Maharashtra, Kerala, Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu before heading to Ayodhya. The intent was clearly to reassure those who worshipped other gods that this was not a ploy to ram Ram down their throats—it was not a 'one nation, one God' theme.

On the day of the ceremony, Ayodhya was transformed into a Vatican-like city with the road leading to the temple lined with performers from across the country singing bhajans devoted to Ram and dancing to them in celebration. Over 7,000 special guests from all walks of life, including celebrities from business, sports, cinema and media, descended on the temple town with a long cavalcade of SUVs transporting them to the mandir. UP chief minister Yogi Adityanath had spent considerable effort in the past four years to massively revamp the city's infrastructure. This included the widening of roads, modernising the airport and railway station and cleaning up the bathing ghats along the holy Sarayu river that flows not far from the temple complex.

PROPRIETY AND PROPITIATION

Modi ensured that the ceremony itself struck the right balance between propriety and propitiation. So, while the prime minister, dressed in a gold kurta with a cream dhoti and patka, remained the cynosure of all eyes, he made sure that RSS chief Bhagwat, CM Adityanath and state governor Anandiben Patel remained an integral part of the ceremony, as also the high priests of the temple. Even as the prime minister participated in the ceremonies, the celebrities assembled in the larger temple complex cheered wildly as they watched the proceedings on giant TV screens set up for them. Indian Air Force helicopters showered petals over them. Modi then offered *dandavat pranam* (prostrating on the ground) to the deified idol. When the time came for speaking on the occasion, Modi shared the dais with Bhagwat, Adityanath and Anandiben, apart from Mahant Nritya Gopal Das and Govind Dev Giriji Maharaj, the president and the treasurer, respectively, of the SRJBTK trust. Both were given a chance to address the gathering.